

# WINDOW PANE

## HUGO CUENOT



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A fly lands on my forehead as I'm lying on the couch, resting my eyes. I move slightly to make it leave, but I can feel its tiny legs just move up to my hair. My arms are heavy and just won't move at the moment. I shake my head again and the fly disappears. My body wakes up slowly from the slumber. I open my eyes, the room is still dark, barely any light filtering through the closed blinds. My tea now cold on the coffee table looks dark and sad, so I take a sip. I left it to steep too long, it's bitter and I feel a black film sticking to my teeth. The cold tiles against my feet help me wake up slowly from my torpidity. I see the fly lazily flying around the room, stuck inside, going in circles. It comes my way for a fraction of a second, but I pray hard for it to leave me alone, and it does, and ends up somewhere in the sink, probably enjoying the leftovers from dinner, or lunch, or both. I stand up, heavily, and walk to my computer. I turn it on, and while it boots up, I pick up the now empty teacup and rinse it in the sink. The

water is splashing the dirty dishes, crusted food falling off from the sides and flowing into the drain. I follow my morning ritual, putting water in the kettle, getting an Earl Grey teabag out of the box and into the cup. I softly pour hot water and sit down by my computer with my tea. The fly is on top of the screen, staring at me. I stare at my blank screen for a minute, dissociating.

I break off the dissociative state and open the blinds to let some light in. From this window I have a detailed view of the neighboring wall fifty centimeters away, grey and filthy. It's still early, the sun is still low and hasn't quite reached my apartment yet, but the grey wall is still reflecting some diffuse light in. I sit back down in front of my computer and open my browser. I have an ungodly number of tabs open, and I navigate through them to pass the time, sipping on my hot tea. The fly has moved on the other side of the screen, probably mocking me. I won't even try to kill it, I'll just let it be. I alternate looking at garden scaping forums and video game footage. I read the discussion on the forums very intently; at the moment I'm at page fourteen out of a hundred and twenty of an open discussion of the proper way to take care of your tomatoes in the summer.

I love it when they put out pictures of their dirty hands in the soil, or the tiny green fruits, like the belly of an alien pregnant woman. I love amassing all of this shared knowledge, I love imagining my inside garden, rich and ripe, overflowing with flowers and fruits. One of the recurrent forum users catches my eye. His username suggests he loves earth, and the small profile picture shows a young man smiling, his head awfully close to the ground, in a weird position. It looks like he's about to be beheaded, but he's delighted about it, like it is the most pleasant thing that could be happening to him. I click on his smiling face and wait for his profile to load. He has hundreds of posts in the forum, on a wide variety of subjects, with an apparent specialty in hydroponic culture. But I'm more interested in the pictures he had posted, I want to see his life, his garden sprouted from his fingers. So, I sift through his pictures; they're usually a bit blurry, like they're all a bit dirty, or he needed them to be dirty to show that he's not a phony, that his dirt-covered hands can't help but take dirty pictures. His dirty hands are sometimes present in the pictures, pointing at a corner, holding some fruit, or simply hanging along his leg. I'm now stuck in a rabbit hole of this guy's pictures; it seems like he has

documented every inch of his large garden, his greenhouse, even his house. In my mind, I make up a puzzle of this man, from every piece of him that appears, I build him up in my mind, in the middle of his plantations.

Among the pieces scrolling through my screen, appears his face. Somebody else took the picture, he's scowling, standing in front of a young tree that just got planted. He looks tall, but it is hard to say standing next to such a small tree. Although he could actually be a giant, and the tree be normal size. Something about him screams "manual work", his big forearms perhaps, or maybe his forever brown fingernails. I love what he represents, a strong male figure, and someone who knows how to use his hands, or maybe I just like the idea of having control over something, having a power dynamic without people. Someone I could never be.

I get sucked in my computer for hours, every day, hours pouring down into it. I feel connected, seen. I can see the world, all at once, like I'm part of it, and maybe somewhere out there, I can be seen as part of it too. I don't feel like the shadow or the ghost that I am in this world. Here, I only exist in the confines of my studio apartment, rarely leaving it. The reality is too

harsh, too bright in the day, and swallowing dark at night. So, I stay in, and I watch the world through my liquid crystal window. I'm a voyeur most of the time there, I like to watch and not partake, like a lurker. But sometimes, I leave my shadowy corner and go out to play with them, leaving chats on message boards, asking a question that nobody has ever asked, or just chatting with someone. Today, by mistake, or by chance, and even though they're everywhere, and easy to access, I found myself on a sex chat for the first time. The website looks antiquated, like it had stayed in a virtual formaldehyde solution for years.

Despite its repugnant appearance, the forum is still active, being used by a handful of people, their number blinking, between twelve and eighteen in the "Chat Sexy No Mic No Cam" category. So far, the whole sexual part of the internet hasn't appealed to me. I know of it, it's hard to ignore, always looming somewhere, a profusion of explicit ads trying to get your attention in a corner, or popping up on your screen, desperate to scam you, or selling you a piece of intimacy, to be shared with someone, or to be enjoyed in the comfort of your home. Maybe their omnipresence has dampened any

interest I could have had for it. Until now. Something stirs in me and pushes me into that chatroom. Inside, some people have detailed profiles where they put out some information about themselves, their age, their height, sometimes a location. I connect with a blank profile, someone like me, a shadow. And the shadow answers back from a shy hello. I freeze for a second, surprised to get an answer back. It is an odd feeling to have somebody on the other side of a screen, somewhere at the end of an endless length of cable, hidden to you, yet willing to have a conversation.

We exchange a few words, cut up words to introduce ourselves. I might not be used to talking online, I know the codes, I know how to pretend to be one of them. He's a man. We live far away from each other. I ask him to describe himself, for some reason it is important for me to have an image of who I'm talking with, even if chances are that he'll change his appearance, not using quite the right words, but I like it anyway, this ideal mental image. He's young, early adulthood, an image of an Australian surfer builds up in my mind. A sunbaked beach rat, his face cut up with a white shark smile. I'm talking with someone describing himself as a movie star and

I love it. The most irrational part of my brain is unbelievably flattered by the clear factitious attraction of this man with me. So, I keep talking with him, describing myself as I think I am, saying the truth I can tell, the concrete truth of the color of my hair, skin and eyes. With the puzzle pieces I leave him of my face and my body, I let him build whoever he wants to be talking to. And it worked. He wants to know what I'm wearing. I know what this question means, much like the rest of the world, the innuendo is clear, and asking this question steers the conversation in a very narrow path leading somewhere I'm not certain I'll like.

My hand hovers over the exit, hesitating to simply flee the situation. But I don't want to flee this time, I want to see how far I can go, can I keep his interest long enough? For him I describe exactly what I'm wearing, without sparing any detail of my gloomy outfit. That doesn't freeze him off, because he is now describing himself shirtless, wearing nothing but his abs. The absurdity of this conversation makes me wonder of the very reality of this interaction; of the reality of the person I'm interacting with. Yet somehow, that doesn't really dampen my interest in him, and I continue the conversation. He's asking more



about my body, and I don't love my body, it's hard to describe the body that you have and don't love, but I tell him about it, about the flesh on my bones, about the hair covering it and the curve the muscles and fat underneath take. I talk about my chest and what's between my legs, but I try to not be too cartesian when I describe it, I try to put a little bit of passion and desire. I translate this body into words and send them away to him to translate back into images. Or into zeros and ones if he happens to be a simple bot, trying to get not into my pants but into my machine. For a few seconds, after sending the messages, I stay suspended, waiting for an answer, or a lack of, perhaps. I stand by, watching and expecting the small three dots to tell me he's typing something. It makes me wonder whether it is important to me or not to have an answer to you getting naked in front of someone. I wouldn't know, I'm not certain I have been naked in front of someone, at least not in this sort of setting, not when we're sharing something of ourselves.

As detached as I think I am, a wave of relief washes over me when an answer from my conversationalist comes back, a simple "Mmh" that I decided to interpret as a validating tone, a nod that stays in the throat. He goes on a lengthy pa-

ragraph about his growing appendage, and how hot he feels about my body, and how excited I'm making him feel. He seems to be going through the masculine rite of masturbation. I imagine him typing with a single hand, the other one lodged on his prick. I'm not aroused by this, but rather fascinated by the exchange.

His tone changes, he stops asking me questions, and now gives me orders. He wants me to touch myself thinking of him. I tell him that I do, I get into this character, I pretend that I'm sweating from the "hotness" of the situation, I pretend that my hands caress my body softly and sexually while I read and imagine myself with him. Creating this character turns me on however. I really get aroused pretending to be all of that for a random man online. I pray inside of me for him to be real, for his desire to be real, for him to really get off on this idea of me, this fantasy. As his grammar fails under the urges, words typed by his single hand, skidding and dropping letters, the more inspired I get to describe him my own expression of desire. Now his words aren't enough, I need to picture him in my head, clearly, his muscles tense, red, the breath getting shorter, twitching. Now I start describing what he could do to me if he were

here, and I to him. That probably sent him over the edge because after that, he stopped responding for five minutes. Either he got bored, or he's cleaning himself up. I'm once again standing by, suspended, waiting. The three small dots appear at the bottom of the screen for a second, then disappear. Then the chatbox disappears. He left.

I'm in a luscious garden, surrounded by trees and large bushes. But everything is hazy, blurry. I try to focus on a leaf and find myself staring into a fractal, dividing into smaller pieces, getting smaller and smaller. It feels like I'm falling standing up. I turn my head in what feels like slow motion, or as if I was stuck in some sort of thick liquid. Everything feels like it is spinning around me and when I blink my eyes, I find myself somewhere else entirely, the garden in the distance looks like a stain, or mold on the wall, and I stare at it, and slowly, as I stare at it, it morphs and I find myself in my bathroom, someone banging on the door, screaming my name. I try and look through the keyhole, and through the hole, I'm right back in the garden. I reach out my hand to touch the bark of the tree next to me, covered in moss, each particle of moss softly coiffed with a droplet of water. This looks like the most inviting surface I have ever

seen, yet the moment my hand is about to touch the surface, my eyes open. I'm in my bed, and it's early in the morning.

A ray of light piercing my dusty room like a lance, landing on a pile of dirty laundry. I get up heavily and walk to the bathroom. I let the pee dribble down the porcelain toilet while I emerge from the slumber. I think back on the dream I just had while I can still remember it. How bizarre to dream of greenery, my mind trying to find an explanation for this apparition. It must be a deep craving from my body to be immersed in nature again; it has been a while.

But I have no desire to go and find a spot outside. I have no desire to feel the wind and see the sky. Right now, I just want to bathe in the cold and blue light on my computer screen. I want to escape my room and this stuffy apartment but stay in it, in the comfort and warmth of it. I don't want the hassle and the stress of going out, I just want to forget it, and escape from within. I realize that the apartment feels cold this morning, the hair along my legs slightly raised and the skin on my arms starting to erect. I check the only window in the room that I usually keep shut during the night. The shutters are not closed all the way, and the window is slightly

ajar. I shut it close in a firm movement, but as I do so, my left foot hits something soft and dark. Believing in an old sock, I start to leave but something shiny in the shapeless form catches my eye. I crouch down towards the object and try to grab it with my hand, but the soft texture and rigidity surprises me. I jolt back crashing on the chair behind me and ending up on the floor.

The shape I took for a simple sock turns out to be the small dead body of a bat that made its way into the apartment during the night. Or some other night. Because for this small body to be already so hard must have been stuck somewhere for a while. Or perhaps it has been sick, another carrier of disease that has landed exactly here to release all his toxins in here, targeting me. The gleam of light that caught my eye was nothing but its tiny black eyes, opened over his furry body, like polished beads in their velvet box, invaluable jewelry. I stare at it for a moment, its shape starting to reveal itself to my eyes adapting to the darkness. I get closer to it, making sure that it is not breathing, that it wasn't pretending from the beginning, trying to get me to let my guard down and attack me, or something. I hold my breath as I get closer, but nothing, it is not moving, the small body still

inert.

I grab a pencil lying next to me and softly push against the body, the tip disappearing under the dark fur and bumping against the rigor mortis. Definitely dead. I decide to take it into my hands, softly cupping the small animal. It is light as air, its wings falling lightly, silky, framed with the most delicate bones. Everything about it seems so fragile I cannot be surprised that it died here, out of its place in a violent place, not made to cater to such dainty beings. I look around the room, trying to figure out what to do with it, trying to find a place to put this delicate corpse, something that feels appropriate to contain it. I noticed the empty plastic box on the kitchen counter that used to contain prunes.

The small body in its transparent coffin looks peaceful, I fold its wings over its body, probably the way it liked to sleep, or just like how I imagine vampires to sleep in their velvet coffins. I put the box in the fridge while I figure out what to do with it. My hands don't really smell like anything, it's like I didn't even touch anything, still I clean them thoroughly with soap. I sit behind my computer and start looking up how to get rid of a body. Maybe I should have been more precise and told the search engine that it

is not a human body, but the body of a bat. Still, I scroll through the results on how to get rid of a human body. I'm now in my element, sifting through the results, trying to find the most relevant, experienced, thought-out forum detailing it.

And there is murder-hypothesis galore online to choose from. The men on these forums all have the perfect way to dispose of a body depending on where you are, how much time you have and the type of body you need to get rid of. However, most of the plans I'm reading advise you to cut the body up in pieces, which, in my situation, seems a little bit excessive. One very popular way is to throw the body in water to get rid of it, which seems appropriate in my case, I do not want to go out and buy a jar of hydrochloric acid to dissolve the small creature in a bucket and then dump the goo in the toilet. I could also very simply bury it, but that seems too formal a solution and would probably require a whole ceremony which I'm not ready for. I notice this commenter who keeps appearing, leaving insightful comments under posts about the subject, and I wonder who they are, and what makes it so interesting about getting rid of bodies, to the point of having covered eve-

ry possible scenario and giving advice to people online. Their profile holds nothing of their true identity and has no distinguishing sign except for the small round profile picture of a beetle.

Coming back to reality, I'm now debating what to do with the small body, what kind of body of water should I take it to. Outside seems complicated, and there are no rivers, sea or even ponds nearby. I go to the fridge and look at the transparent coffin and take it out of it. I take the small bat out of its box and shroud it in white tissue paper. I take the small package with me to the bathroom and place it delicately in the toilet bowl I was pissing in earlier. The paper turns transparent as the water touches it, and soon the black body appears underneath its shroud.

Thinking a short prayer to myself, I flush. Once the water comes down, the black body still floats at the surface, white paper dissolving in the water around it. I flush again. But again, the bat refuses to go below the water, refuses to go where its cries can't guide it. I take the small body out of the water and try to dry it as best as I can with a towel, taking care of this sleeping baby like a parent. Still undecided on its future, I put it back in its box and this time, to give me more time, I leave it in the small freezer compartment.